

Idols vandalised in three Panchagarh upazilas in two weeks

Only one person, a boy suffering from a mental illness, was detained in connection with the incidents.

Stream Report

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Photo: Collected

Incidents of idol vandalism have occurred three upazilas of Panchagarh within 15 days, including two cases involving idols that were being prepared for Durga Puja and another involving a Kali idol.

The latest incident took place around midnight today (1 October) at the North Toriya Kalibari Sarbajanin Durga Puja mandap in Atwari's Toriya union. Police, the upazila nirbahi officer and law enforcement personnel visited the site after receiving the report this morning.

Police said the idol, which was still being sculpted, was knocked over from outside with a bamboo pole during the night. The damaged idol was later immersed following Hindu religious customs.

Atwari Police Station Officer-in-Charge Matiar Rahman said police visited the site after receiving the report. No case has been filed yet, but police are conducting a preliminary investigation, he added.



Photo: Collected

Earlier, on 25 September, an idol that was being prepared at the Galandhi Chowrangi Shri Shri Durga Mandir in Debiduba union of Debiganj upazila was vandalised.

Debiganj Police Station OC Musa Mia said unidentified people broke parts of the buffalo and peacock figures after the priest and artisans had left the mandap and no one was around.

Police teams, the district detective branch, CID and PBI visited the scene and a case was subsequently filed with the Debiganj Police Station by Radhanath Barman, general secretary of the temple committee.

No one has been arrested in connection with the incident so far, police said.

The other incident occurred on 17 September at a Kali temple in Aminnagar Bakshiganj village of Sakowa union in Boda upazila.

Police said an 18-year-old youth, Nur Mohammad Imon, vandalised the idol and was later detained. Locals told police that Imon had been living in Dhaka with his parents and studying at a madrasa.

After developing mental health problems several months ago, he received treatment and was brought to his aunt's home in Boda around 20 days before the incident for further treatment.

According to police, Imon left home on the day of the incident and, while walking around the area, entered the Kali temple and vandalised the idol.

He was later detained from his grandfather's house.

As his family produced medical documents relating to his treatment, he was handed over to them on the instructions of senior officials. Police also said arrangements had been made to admit him to a mental health facility in Dhaka.

The temple authorities later gave a written statement saying they would not pursue a legal case, after which the damaged idol was immersed according to religious customs.

Police said additional surveillance and regular patrols were continuing in the area to prevent any further untoward incidents.

Harish Chandra Roy, general secretary of the Kshatriya Samiti's Panchagarh district unit and a leader of the district Puja Celebration Council, said vandalising an idol was an expression of religious hatred.

"An idol represents the emotions and sentiments of Sanatanis, even when it is still under construction. We want this country to belong to everyone, regardless of religion or caste, so that all can practise their respective faiths freely," he said.

He also said such incidents had occurred in the past and continued to occur, while expressing concern that perpetrators had not been brought to justice in previous cases.

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